and I think her prayers and blessings have given me the strength to go out and perform, so a big thank you to my mother for all the sacrifices.

In my schooldays, for four years I stayed with my uncle and my aunt, because my school was quite far from my home, and they treated me like their son. My aunt – after having had a hard day's play, I would be half asleep and she would be feeding me food so that I could go and play again tomorrow. I can't forget these moments. I am like their son and I am glad that it has continued to be the same way.

My eldest brother, Nitin, and his family have always encouraged me. My eldest brother doesn't like to talk much, but the one thing he always told me is, 'Whatever you do, I know you will give a hundred per cent, and I have full confidence and faith in you.' His encouragement meant a lot to me. My sister, Savita, and her family, was no different. The first cricket bat of my life was presented to me by my sister, it was a Kashmir willow bat … but that is where the journey began. She is one of those many who still continue to fast when I bat, so thank you very much.

Ajit, my brother, now what do I talk about him? I don't know, really. We've, we've lived this dream together. He was the one who sacrificed his career for my cricket. He spotted the spark in me. And it all started from the age of eleven when he took me to Achrekar Sir, my coach, and from there on my life changed. You will find this hard to believe that even last night he called me and we were discussing my dismissal, knowing that there was a remote chance of batting again, but just that, the habit which we have developed and the rapport that we have developed, since my birth, it has continued and it will continue. Maybe even when I'm not playing cricket we will still be discussing technique. Various things, various things we agreed upon, my technique, and so many technical things which I didn't agree with him, we have had arguments and disagreements, but in the end when I look back at all those things, if that hadn't happened in my life, I would have been a lesser cricketer.

The most beautiful thing happened to me in 1990 when I met my wife, Anjali. Those were, those were special years and it has continued and it will always continue that way. I know, I know Anjali, being a doctor, there was a wonderful career in front of her. When we decided to have a family, Anjali took the initiative to step back and say that, 'You continue with your cricket and I'll take the responsibility of the family.' Without, without that, I don't think I would have been able to play cricket freely